

PART 4D: XANATHAR'S LAIR

[by Justin Alexander – January 31st, 2019](#)



Xanathar stole the *Stone of Golorr* from Lord Neverember and he stole one of the three Eyes from the Zhentarim. Then he lost the *Stone* when Dalakhar took it from him.

As a result, once the PCs become truly involved with the Grand Game, it is likely that Xanathar is on a level playing field with Manshoon and the Cassalanter, holding but a single Eye.

EVENT SCHEDULE & SURVEILLANCE OPPORTUNITY

Throughout the festival season, Xanathar hosts gladiatorial games every 2-4 days. As noted in Part 3B, those interested in attending the fights must learn the secret pass phrases and go to gladiatorial gathering points throughout the city.

In addition to the arena itself (X6), those attending these fights are allowed to congregate in areas X2, X17, and X18. Servants circulate through these areas, serving drinks and food. Additional guards are placed in the entrance to hallways X21 and X22, however, to turn guests away. (See the *Tournament* adversary roster, below.)

Panopticus Dwarves: The panopticus dwarves in Area X16 keep the following areas constantly under surveillance:

- Area X2 – Entrance Hall
- Area X6 – Arena
- Area X18 – Audience Chamber
- Area X23 – Antechamber of Madness
- Area X32 – Downstairs Hallway

Identifying the function of the ghostly eyes during onsite surveillance is probably crucial to carrying out an effective heist. Their function can be determined with a DC 14 Intelligence (Arcana) check, making it clear that there must be a panopticus circle somewhere nearby being monitored by a number of watchers equal to the number of ghostly eyes. A *detect magic* spell combined with a DC 14 Intelligence (Arcana) check will allow the caster to follow the magical lines of force between the eyes and the panopticus circle, effectively triangulating the location of the circle if they can observe at least two eyes.

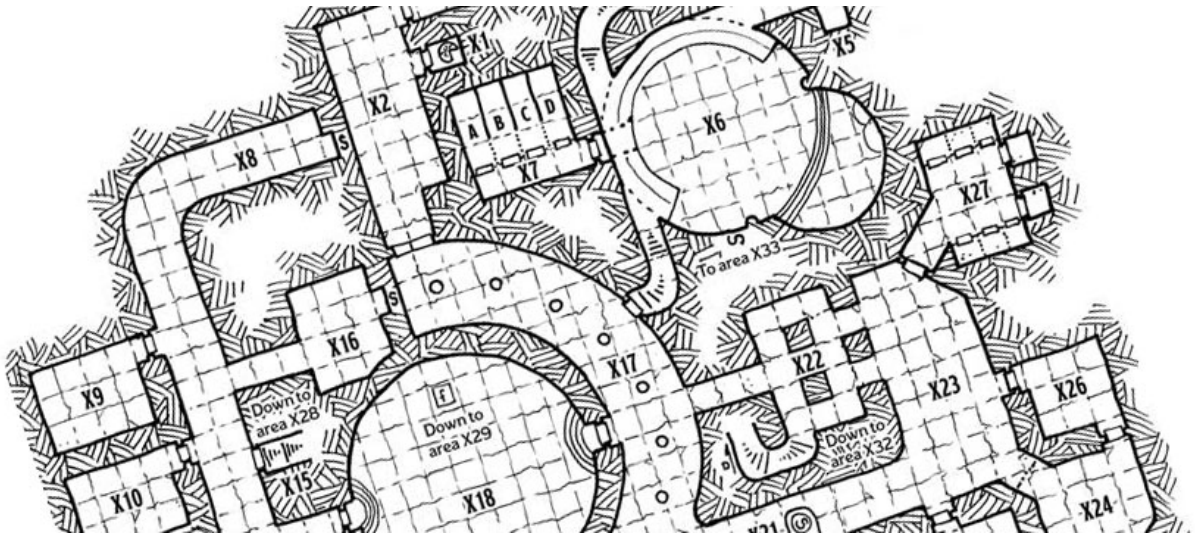
In addition, as described in Area X16 below, the panopticus circle can be suborned.



DESIGN NOTE

Note that the list of areas surveilled by the panopticus dwarves is deliberately altered. The easiest access to Xanathar's Sanctum (X19) is through the door in Area X18. By placing a scrying sensor there, it more or less forces the PCs to either suborn the panopticus or find an alternative route to Area X19.

BLUEPRINT NOTES



There are no blueprints of Xanathar's Lair to be found. Questioning Xanatharian agents might give the PCs an opportunity to piece out information, but convincing them to do so when the consequence is Xanathar's displeasure is not an easy task.

Far easier is contacting one of the many people who have attended the gladiatorial games to describe what they've seen. In general their recollections will be limited to the "public" areas listed above, but:

- There's one halfling who remembers seeing some of Xanathar's personal guard come through the secret door between X17 and X16 ("I was looking at this fresco of a leafless tree that had lidless eyes embedded in its branches and suddenly – presto! – the whole wall swung back and some of those shifty-eyed bugbears came through"). She didn't see how the door operates.
- If they get particularly lucky, they might track down a foolhardy couple who snuck through the door from the Audience Chamber (X18) into Xanathar's Sanctum (X19) and can describe what they saw there.

OTHER OPPORTUNITIES

As described on p. 101-102 of [Dragon Heist](#), there are a number of other powerful factions throughout the city that are aware of Xanathar's Lair and can reveal the secret entrance to Area X1.

There is a magical portal to Xanathar's Lair in the Guild Sewer Hideout in *Chapter 1: Finding Floom*. It's possible (although unlikely) that the PCs already gained access to the lair at that time. If not, they could theoretically put the hideout under surveillance, ambush Nihiloor, and use his amulet to activate the portal and enter the lair.

If Ott Steeltoes is rescued from the Zhentarim (see Part 3B), he may also be gulled into leading the PCs to this secret entrance.

PLAYER TWO ENTERS THE GAME

Whenever the PCs choose to launch their actual heist, it turns out that Jarlaxle is simultaneously attempting to do the exact same thing.

The Team: Jarlaxle's team consists of himself, one of his lieutenants, and a Bregan D'Aerthe response team (see [Part 3C](#)).

Entrance: Generally speaking, there are three methods of entry to Xanathar's Lair. You can come in the secret entrance (X1), you can try to sneak in from Skullport (X4), or you can be brought in as part of the audience for the gladiatorial games (also via X4, but almost certainly arriving in X6 before you'll have a chance to slip away).

I recommend having Jarlaxle's team use a method of entry which the PCs *didn't*. So if the PCs came in through X1, for example, then Jarlaxle's team arrived from either Skullport or as part of the crowd for the gladiatorial tournament.

Jarlaxle's Plan: The ace in the hole for Jarlaxle is that he's aware of the secret passage (X14) leading to Xanathar's Sanctum. How, exactly, he gains access to the passage is heavily dependent on the circumstances in which the heist takes place. (And, dramatically speaking, the DM should ideally make it cross the path of the PCs' heist as much as possible: Seeing Jarlaxle or his lieutenants from across a crowded room or at the far end of a deserted hallway about their business will be a satisfying complication. This will also be easier to do if Jarlaxle's team includes someone the PCs have seen before during the Grand Game, if that's not Jarlaxle himself.)



Jarlaxle's *modus operandi* will generally be using secondary teams to create distractions in order to draw people (including Xanathar) away from where he wants his primary team to be. For example, if the heist is going down during a gladiatorial match, Jarlaxle's plan might look something like this:

- One of his men picks a fight with the guards blocking entrance to hallway X21. This draws the guards preventing entry to X22 away from their posts.
- Jarlaxle's lieutenant and two more of his men slip into X22 and down the stairs to X32. They make their way to the Recreation Hall (X28) and throw smoke bombs through the door.
- Men from X28 rush to the Audience Chamber (X18), causing the guards on the door there to rush out to X8. Jarlaxle and his remaining men slip through the door behind them and then through the secret door to X19.
- After locating the Eye, they go down the emergency escape route to X21. Jarlaxle uses his *hat of disguise* to don the appearance of Ahmaergo, orders the guards to assist in the commotion downstairs, meets up with the rest of his team as they emerge back up the stairs and through Area X22, and then heads for the exit.

Nar'l Xibrindas: N'arl is an agent of Bregan D'Aerthe, but his ability to directly assist Jarlaxle during the heist is limited due to the presence of the grell bodyguard Xanathar has placed on him. Jarlaxle would also prefer to keep him *in situ* as a valuable source of intel until the Grand Game has concluded.

However, once the distractions start causing turmoil, Nar'l might contribute to Jarlaxle's plan in subtler ways. (For example, by ordering key guards out of the way on plausible pretexts at the right moment.)

Effect on the PCs: The presence of Jarlaxle's team will almost certainly cause complications for the PCs' plans, but the PCs' actions are also likely to cause complications for Jarlaxle. It will be most satisfying if you let *both* those things play out naturally, and keep in mind that it's equally possible for the PCs to *benefit* from security holes Jarlaxle opens for his own team (and vice versa).

DESIGN NOTE

Competing with a second crew trying to pull off the same job is a really exciting situation that opens up a lot of unique tactical choices and dramatic situations. But there's another reason for including Jarlaxle's crew here: Xanathar's Lair is probably the hardest nut to actually crack. If things get out of hand, the presence of Jarlaxle's crew gives the DM a tool to either (a) easily pull heat off of the PCs or (b) steal the Eye, prompting an easier heist at the Sea Maidens Faire.

THE LAIR

X7 – *Cell Block*: See *Dragon Heist* for full description.

- **Questioning Samara**: Samara was part of the original delegation sent to Xanathar to negotiate a Golorr-related allegiance. The rest of her team was killed, but she was thrown in here and has been fighting for her life ever since. Her information is dated, but she believes that Xanathar holds the *Stone of Golorr* (which is the key to Neverember's Enigma, although she doesn't know that's half a million gold coins) and that he's taken Manshoon's Eye. She also knows that there are two other Eyes. She can tell PCs that Manshoon is based out of Kolat Towers, and that the Towers can be accessed from Yellowspire.

X12 – *Ahmaergo's Quarters*: In addition to the normal entry for this room, the chest contains *A Briefing for Xanathar Concerning the Grand Game*.

X16 – *Panopticus Station*: In addition to the normal entry for this room, it is possible to suborn the panopticus network. A DC 16 Intelligence (Arcana) check can determine that altering two specific runes in the circle will create an "echo" in the vision provided by the ghostly eyes. (In other words, yes, they can loop the video feed.) Doing so will require sneaking past the dwarves, but that's not too hard because they're only half-aware of their immediate surroundings.

X18 – *Audience Chamber*: In addition to the normal entry for this room, there is a ghostly eye scrying sensor.

X19 – *Xanathar's Sanctum*: In addition to the normal entry for this room, Xanathar keeps the Eye in Sylgar's fishbowl.

X28 – *Guild Recreation Hall*: In contradiction of the normal entry for this room, there is no scrying sensor in this room.

X35 – *Nar'l Xibrindas' Office*: In addition the normal entry for this room, the desk contains a *Report on the Seven Masks Theater*.

- **Report on the Seven Masks Theater**: A letter Rostrum Feilcook of the Fellowship of Innkeepers, a guild which also oversees local theaters, confirms "your exalted suspicion" regarding the new ownership of the Seven Masks Theater, insofar as the purported owner – "Rongquan Mystere" – is actually being funded by another source, most likely with money originating from outside Waterdeep. A second letter, dated two days later, reports that Rostrum has identified Rongquan's mysterious patron as "Captain Zord of the Sea Maidens Faire" with his money "originating from Luskan".
- *GM Note*: Nar'l Xibrindas stole these letters and hid them before Xanathar could see them.

ADVERSARY ROSTER – XANATHAR’S LAIR (STANDARD)

Xanathar (01-25%)	beholder zombie + 4 gas spores	Area X2 – Watched Hall
Noska Ur’gray (01-25%) + Prisoners	animated armor	Area X5 – Horror’s Alcove
10 bandits	telepathically summoned by X	if X present, see <i>A Private Fight</i>
Noska Ur’gray (25-50%) + Rust Monster	Area X6 – Arena	see p. 104 for prisoner list
Ahmaergo (01-50%)	Area X7 – Cell Block	not present during <i>A Private Fight</i>
Thorvin Twinbeard	Area X9 – Guild Barracks	
	Area X10 – Noska’s Quarters	
	Area X11/X12 – Ahmaergo’s Quarters	
	Area X13 – Thorvin’s Workshop	
	Panopticus Dwarves	Area X16 – Panopticus Station observe
through ghostly eyestalks		
Xanathar (25-50%)	Area X18 – Audience Chamber	if X present, see <i>A Public Audience</i>
Xanathar (51-75%, with Ott Steeltoes)	Area X19 – Xanathar’s Sanctum	talking to his fish
Xanathar (76-00%, sleeping)	Area X19 – Xanathar’s Sanctum	
1 kuo-toa whip + 6 kuo-toa	Area X23 – Antechamber of Madness	
Nihiloor (01-50%) + drow prisoner	Area X24 – Extraction Chamber	
	Nihiloor’s Prisoners	Area X25 – Food for Thought
Nihiloor (51-00%) + 4 intellect devourers	Area X26 – Spawning Pool	
3 kuo-toa whips + prisoners	Area X27 – Nihiloor’s Prison	see p. 111 for prisoner list
10 bandits +2 goblins	Area X28 – Recreation Hall	
2 gazers + 7 chefs	Area X30 – Gourmet Kitchen	
	Halfpling Cook	Area X31 – The Other Kitchen
Nar’l Xibrindas	Area X35 – Narl’s Office	

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

When entering any public area, there is a 1 in 10 chance of having a random encounter.

d4	Encounter
1	Flutterfoot Zipswiggle (see DH p. 104)
2	Ahmaergo (conducting a routine inspection)
3	N’arl Xibrindas + Grell bodyguard
4	Ott Steeltoes

A PRIVATE FIGHT

- Xanathar (invisible in southeast alcove)
- Ahmaergo
- Noska Ur’gray
- 10 bandits + 5 bugbears as an audience
- 2 goblins serving salted rat intestines and stirge meat pies
- 1d4 random combatants from Area X7

A PUBLIC AUDIENCE

- Xanathar, using psychedelic light display to deliver an incoherent, self-aggrandizing speech to a group of sycophantic underlings who have never seen his true form
- Nar’l Xibrindas
- Grell Bodyguard
- 10 bandits
- 2 duergar

ADVERSARY ROSTER – DURING TOURNAMENT

During a tournament, there will be gathered an audience of 30-60 people. This crowd will either be in the Arena (X6) or congregating socially in Promenade (X17) and Audience Chamber (X18).

GUARDS: Xanathar's bandits act as guards. (These numbers are included in the adversary roster below.)

- **X6:** 2 guards at either end of the audience.
- **X17:** 2 guards are stationed at the exits to X2, X21, and X22.
- **X18:** 2 guards on all three doors.

XANATHAR: Xanathar enters the Audience Chamber (X18), gives a short speech extolling how wonderful it is that he's doing this for everyone, and then floats through the Promenade (X17) to the Arena (X6), where he sets up court in the southeast corner.

THE ARENA CROWD:

- Xanathar
- Ahmaergo
- Thorvin Twinbeard (01-50%)
- Nihilor (01-50%)
- Ott Steeltoes
- Nar'l Xibrindas (01-50%)

IN THE ARENA: See *Dragon Heist*, p. 114 for details on participating in the tournament.

ADVERSARY ROSTER

Arena Crowd + 4 bandits	beholder zombie + 4 gas spores	Area X2 – Watched Hall
Noska Ur'gray + Prisoners	animated armor	Area X5 – Horror's Alcove
Thorvin Twinbeard (51-00%)	telepathically summoned by X	
through ghostly eyestalks	Area X6 – Arena	
6 bandits	Area X7 – Cell Block	see p. 104 for prisoner list
6 bandits	Noska's Rust Monster	Area X10 – Noska's Quarters
1 kuo-toa whip + 6 kuo-toa	Area X13 – Thorvin's Workshop	
Nihiloor (51-75%) + drow prisoner	Panopticus Dwarves	Area X16 – Panopticus Station observe
Nihiloor (76-00%) + 4 intellect devourers	Area X17 – Promenade	
3 kuo-toa whips + prisoners	Area X18 – Audience Chamber	
4 bandits + 2 goblins	Area X23 – Antechamber of Madness	
2 gazers + 7 chefs	Area X24 – Extraction Chamber	
Nar'l Xibrindas (51-00%)	Nihiloor's Prisoners	Area X25 – Food for Thought
	Area X26 – Spawning Pool	
	Area X27 – Nihiloor's Prison	see p. 111 for prisoner list
	Area X28 – Recreation Hall	
	Area X30 – Gourmet Kitchen	
	Halfling Cook	Area X31 – The Other Kitchen
	Area X35 – Narl's Office	

STAT REFERENCE

Ahmaergo – DH p. 193
Flutterfoot Zipswiggle – DH p. 104
Thorvin Twinbeard – dwarven commoner, MM p. 345 (DH p. 216)
N’arl Xibrindas – drow mage, MM p. 129 (DH p. 211)
Noska Ur’gray – shield dwarf thug, MM p. 350 (DH p. 213)
Ott Steeltoes – dwarf cultist, MM p. 345 (DH p. 214)

Bandits – MM p. 343
Bugbears – MM p. 33
Duergar – MM p. 122
Grell – MM p. 172
Kuo-toa / Kuo-toa whip – MM p. 199-200
Chefs – kobolds, MM p. 195
Halfling Cook – commoner, MM p. 345

QUESTIONING THE HENCHMEN

Any member of the Xanathar Guild will be fairly familiar with all of the public spaces in the lair.

- Xanathar is even more paranoid than usual right now and hasn’t left his lair in weeks. That isn’t likely to change as long as the gang war with the Zhentarim is ongoing.
- Xanathar has some kind of machine that “wakes him up in emergencies”. (*GM Note: This is a mangled version of what his dream machine (X20) is actually for.*)
- Virtually all of the Xanatharians steer clear of the mind flayer’s demesne (X23-X27). It’s not unheard of for even loyal members of the Guild to disappear over there. As a result, they don’t know much about the layout or what’s there (although they know prisoners are delivered over there). Conniving Guild members might try to convince the PCs that this is where whatever it is they’re looking for is located (with the expectation that Nihiloor will eat their brains).
- Xanathar doesn’t allow anyone to enter the Area X33 and most don’t even know what’s in there, but some know that there’s a secret door connecting the Arena (X6) and “whatever Xanathar has hidden down there”.

N’arl Xibrindas knows more than most. He’s even snuck into the Crypt of Xanathars Past (X33). But he’ll also suspect that anyone questioning him is actually an agent of Xanathar trying to reveal him as a double agent.

